However, Oppenheimer learned quickly. Within a year, graduate students and postdocs began flocking to Berkeley from all over America to learn physics from him, and within several years he had made Berkeley a more attractive place even than Europe for American theoretical physics postdocs.

One of Oppenheimer's postdocs, Robert Serber, later described what it was like to work with him: "Oppie (as he was known to his Berkeley students) was quick, impatient, and had a sharp tongue, and in the earliest days of his teaching he was reputed to have terrorized the students. But after five years of experience he had mellowed (if his earlier students were to be believed). His course [on quantum mechanics] was an inspirational as well as an educational achievement. He transmitted to his students a feeling of the beauty of the logical structure of physics and an excitement about the development of physics. Almost everyone listened to the course more than once, and Oppie occasionally had difficulty in dissuading students from coming a third or fourth time.¼

"Oppie's way of working with his research students was also original. His group consisted of 8 or 10 graduate students and about a half dozen postdoctoral fellows. He met the group once a day in his office. A little before the appointed time, the members straggled in and disposed themselves on the tables and about the walls. Oppie came in and discussed with one after another the status of the student's research problem while the others listened and offered comments. All were exposed to a broad range of topics. Oppenheimer was interested in everything; one subject after another was introduced and coexisted with all the others. In an afternoon they might discuss electrodynamics, cosmic rays, astrophysics and nuclear physics."

Each spring Oppenheimer piled books and papers into his convertible and several students into the rumble seat, and drove down to Pasadena. "We thought nothing of giving up our houses or apartments in Berkeley," said Serber, "confident that we could find a garden cottage in Pasadena for twenty-five dollars a month."

For each problem that interested him, Oppenheimer would select a student or postdoc to work out the details. For Landau's problem, the question of whether a neutron core could keep the Sun hot, he selected Serber.